EL SALVADOR (6 November)

Normal rains have resumed following an unusually long July dry spell ("canicula") which severely affected crops in several growing areas. Sowing of the 2000/01 second season (main) sorghum crop is underway while maize plantings from the second season crop continue to grow under favourable conditions. Early production forecasts indicate that some 570 000 tonnes of maize should be collected, which compares to 650 000 tonnes the year before and the last 5-year average of 596 000 tonnes. This is primarily the result of the adverse dry weather which affected the first season crops. By contrast, production of sorghum is expected to be above average because of increased second season crop plantings. Planting of the second season bean crop is completed and aggregate output (both crops) is provisionally forecast to be an average 68 000 tonnes. An average paddy output is also anticipated. Food assistance, as a component of various reconstruction projects (food for work) is still being distributed in some areas, following hurricane "Mitch" devastating impact at the end of 1998.

Wheat imports in marketing year 2000/01 (July/June) are forecast to be about 180 000 tonnes, similar to the previous year. Maize imports should increase from 175 000 tonnes to about 245 000 tonnes to compensate for the losses in production. Rice imports in 2001 (January/December) should be similar to this yearï¿½s some 20 000 tonnes.

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